

Hamburger Hill

The American push for Ap Bia Mountain, later known as Hamburger Hill, was the product of General Abrams's positional strategy. A grim and grueling battle, it produced a high body count on both sides and further inflamed public debate on US conduct of the war.

◀◀ BEFORE

The US top command in Vietnam had changed, but skepticism of American strategy remained.

THE END OF ATTRITION

Strategy under General Westmoreland had followed the **attrition model**, which relied on large unit operations intended to produce body count and to exhaust the enemy. By 1969, questions were being raised about what actual territory South Vietnam controlled, how the use of massive firepower conflicted with **pacification programs**, and what moral price the US was paying for relying on attrition.

Westmoreland's attrition strategy underestimated the value of holding territory. Just like his predecessor, General Abrams was prepared to use US combat power, but his new idea was to use it not just to take out the North Vietnamese Army (NVA), but to deny its forces access to major population centers. To accomplish that objective, he sought to target key locations and not just enemy personnel.

Abrams makes plans

In 1969, General Abrams designed a large-scale assault that utilized US and South Vietnamese (ARVN) units to prevent the NVA from launching attacks on cities in the I Corps Tactical Zone: the provinces of Quang Tri, Thua Thien, Quang Nam, Quang Tin, and Quang Ngai, all in the north of South Vietnam.

On May 10, 1969, Abrams launched Operation Apache Snow, which was intended to protect the cities of Hue and Da Nang by targeting the NVA's logistical network and staging areas between the Laotian border and the coast.

Unpopular strategy

The heaviest fighting of Apache Snow occurred in Ap Bia Mountain in the A Shau Valley. Marked on US military maps as Hill 937—meaning it was 3,074 feet (937 m) high—it was known to locals as the Mountain of the Crouching Beast. The US would later come to know it as Hamburger Hill—so called because the terrible carnage there made it akin to a human meat grinder.

Carnage on the hill

Units of the Third Brigade of the 101st Airborne Division, the Ninth Marine Regiment, and ARVN First Division's Third Regiment were flown in by transport helicopters, to approach up the hill and attack the NVA on the top. Rather than retreat, the NVA on the hill decided to stand and fight on the high ground, and combat raged there for 10 days.

After one US regiment attacked with little success, two regiments of the 101st Airborne, and the ARVN regiment, reinforced the attacking force. The tenacity of the US and ARVN ground forces—and the heavy bombardment by air support with B-52s—dislodged the defenders, but the fog of war prolonged the engagement. A torrential downpour on May 18 turned the mountain slopes into mudslides, and on two occasions US helicopter gunships mistakenly struck elements of the 101st Airborne approaching the ridge. However,